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About the Author

Thomas Stearns Eliot (1888 – 1965) was an essayist, a critic, a playwright and a pioneering poet of the twentieth century. He attended Smith Academy in St. Louis and then the Milton Academy in Massachusetts. He graduated from Harvard University and then left for France and the Sorbonne to study philosophy. Eliot returned to Harvard and deepened his knowledge by reading Indian philosophy and studying Sanskrit. He also finished his advanced degree at Harvard. Some of his popular poems include '*The Wasteland*', '*Love Song of J. Alfred Prufrock*', '*Ash Wednesday*', '*Four Quartets*', '*Journey of the Magi*', '*After Strange Gods*' and '*Naming of Cats*'. T.S. Eliot won the Order of Merit and received the Nobel Prize for Literature in the year 1948.

Glossary

defy – to resist or to challenge

bafflement – total confusion

Scotland Yard – the headquarters of London Metropolitan Police Service

Flying Squad – a police force ready to plunge into action

levitation – the action of rising and floating in air

fakir – a holy person who lives on alms and has the power to levitate

ginger – alert and cautious

fiend – demon

feline – cat

depravity – evil quality

larder – cupboard for storing food

rifle – ransack to steal

Peke – a Pekinese dog

stifle – to suppress someone from acting

trellis – wooden bar used as a support for creepers

Admiralty – a Government Department that administered the British Navy

deceitfulness – cunningness

suavity – confidence and sophistication

alibi – a claim of evidence that one was elsewhere when a crime was committed

Mungojerrie and Griddlebone – fictional characters specialised in petty thefts and mischief in T.S. Eliot's book 'Old Possom's Book of Practical Cats'

Napoleon of Crime– the commanding leader of criminals

A. Based on your understanding of the poem, answer the following questions in a sentence or two.

i. What is Macavity's nickname?

ii. Why is the Flying Squad frustrated?